

Credit - Drishti Ias

India-South Africa Technology Partnership and Africa Strategy



For Prelims: Artificial Intelligence (AI), Digital Public Infrastructure , Square Kilometre Array , Southern African Customs Union , African Continental Free Trade Area

For Mains: India-Africa Relations: Evolution, Significance and Challenges, Role of Technology, Diplomacy in Foreign Policy

Source: PIB

Why in News?

In June 2026, **India and South Africa** upgraded their 31-year-old science and technology partnership (established under the 1995 S&T Agreement) from research-focused cooperation to industrial co-production.

- The partnership was further strengthened through a Telangana-South Africa collaboration framework, highlighting the growing strategic depth of **India-Africa** ties and their role as a source of “stability in a turbulent world.”

Summary

- **India and South Africa have upgraded their partnership from traditional research cooperation to technology-driven industrial co-production** , focusing on AI, DPI, critical minerals, healthcare, green energy, and advanced manufacturing, while strengthening India-Africa strategic ties.
- **India's broader Africa strategy is shifting from credit-led development to economic integration and supply-chain resilience** , leveraging regional trade blocs, AfCFTA, critical mineral partnerships, and Global South cooperation to enhance trade, investment, and geopolitical influence.

What are the Core Priorities of the India - South

Africa Next-Generation Technology Partnership?

- **Pivoting to Emerging Frontiers:** Both nations have mandated **Artificial Intelligence (AI), Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI), and Advanced Manufacturing** as the primary pillars for the next phase of bilateral technology deployment.
 - The partnership is actively expanding into **Quantum Technologies , Genomics, and Cyber-Physical Systems**, moving away from theoretical research to focus on scalable technology commercialization.
- **Scaling Up Hydrogen Energy and Biotech:** Collaborative frameworks are being structured around **renewable energy , hydrogen technologies, and vaccine** development to leverage India's affordable healthcare innovation ecosystem and South Africa's green energy transition targets.
- **Expanding Deep Space and Astronomy Ties:** The two sides reviewed their flagship cooperation on the **Square Kilometre Array (SKA) project** , recognizing it as a critical driver for advanced global computing capabilities, big data analytics, and human resource development.
- **Translating Science into Social Impact:** Future co-funded initiatives will be strictly evaluated based on their **capacity to generate local employment, improve public health systems**, and create inclusive digital platforms tailored for developing economies.
- **Telangana-South Africa Partnership:** Telangana signed a direct collaboration framework with South Africa, leveraging **Hyderabad's strengths in IT, Global Capability Centers (GCCs), defense, aerospace, healthcare, and pharmaceuticals** .
 - The partnership aims to promote medical tourism, bulk drug and vaccine co-production, resilient healthcare supply chains, and investment cooperation in agro-processing and advanced manufacturing, while encouraging **South African participation in Telangana's global investment summits**.

How is India Realigning its Economic Strategy in Africa?

- **Shift from Continental to Regional Trade Agreements:** India has paused plans for a continent-wide FTA and is instead prioritizing agreements with regional blocs such as the **Southern African Customs Union (SACU)** , enabling easier movement of goods across **Botswana, Eswatini, Lesotho, Namibia, and South Africa** .
- **Protecting India's Investment Footprint:** With cumulative Indian investments in Africa reaching **USD 80 billion** , New Delhi is pursuing **tailored economic frameworks** to safeguard existing investments, strengthen MSME participation, and reduce exposure to regional instability.
- **Diversifying Fertilizer and Energy Supply Chains:** To mitigate disruptions in traditional Gulf supply routes, India is expanding fertilizer and energy partnerships with **Algeria, Tunisia, Libya, and Morocco** , enhancing agricultural and energy security.
- **Securing Critical Minerals for the Green Transition:** India is embedding access to **lithium, cobalt, rare earth elements, and other strategic minerals** into bilateral partnerships, supporting domestic EV manufacturing and the **National Green Hydrogen Mission** , while promoting local mineral processing.
- **Leveraging the AfCFTA Market:** India is increasingly using the **African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA)** , a **USD 3.4 trillion market covering 1.4 billion people** , by establishing manufacturing and processing hubs in countries such as South Africa and Kenya for continent-wide market access.

- **Transition to Co-Production:** While India has extended over **USD 12 billion in Lines of Credit across 42 African countries**, its engagement is now shifting toward **industrial co-production, technology partnerships, skill development, healthcare collaboration, and value-chain integration**, as reflected in recent India-South Africa agreements.
- **Activating the BRICS Innovation Framework:** India has invited South Africa's active participation in the upcoming **BRICS Science, Technology, and Innovation Ministerial Meeting in Chennai (August 2026)** to drive collaborative research in high-performance computing and precision agriculture.
- **Reciprocal African Forum Engagement:** The South African delegation extended an invitation to India for the **Science Forum South Africa 2026**, creating a parallel platform for pan-African knowledge exchange and institutional linkage.

What is the Geopolitical Significance of Deepened India-Africa Ties?

- **Championing the Global South:** India and the **African Union** are emerging as a powerful voice for the Global South, advocating reforms in the UN Security Council, Bretton Woods institutions, and climate finance architecture through platforms such as BRICS.
 - Simultaneously, under the **SAGAR (Security and Growth for All in the Region) doctrine**, India has strengthened maritime cooperation with African nations through joint naval engagements, maritime domain awareness initiatives, and information-sharing via the **Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region (IFC-IOR)** to secure vital sea lanes against piracy and illicit trafficking.
- **A Counterweight to "Debt-Trap" Diplomacy:** India's engagement, strictly governed by the **Kampala Principles (2018)**, offers a stark alternative to the opaque, heavily state-backed infrastructure loans provided by other major powers (e.g., China's FOCAC).
 - India emphasizes transparent, demand-driven capacity building that respects sovereign financial integrity.
- **Sustaining Global Peacekeeping Operations:** India's historical commitment to **African stability** is evidenced by the presence of over 5,000 active **Indian peacekeepers** in volatile hotspots like **South Sudan and the DRC**, reinforcing India's credentials as a net security provider.
- **Institutionalizing the Diplomatic Footprint:** By opening 17 new diplomatic missions bringing the total to 46 across the continent, India has ensured direct, robust diplomatic visibility in virtually every region of Africa, facilitating real-time crisis management and localized geopolitical intelligence.
- **Reinvigorating the India-Africa Forum Summit (IAFS):** The convening of **IAFS-IV** resets the continental roadmap, transitioning bilateral dialogues from sporadic engagements to sustained, structural geopolitical alignments at the highest executive levels.

What are the Major Structural Challenges in the India-Africa Relationship?

- **Project Implementation Deficits:** Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs reports have repeatedly highlighted severe bureaucratic delays in the disbursement and execution of targeted **Lines of Credit (LoC)**.
 - These delays erode diplomatic trust and diminish the tangible impact of India's developmental assistance.
- **Asymmetry in Geopolitical Competition:** China's deep economic penetration via the **Belt and Road**

- Initiative (BRI) and the Forum on China-Africa Cooperation (FOCAC)** vastly outscales Indian sovereign investments.
- Indian private capital often struggles to compete with heavily subsidized, state-backed Chinese mega-projects.
 - **Political Instability and Regional Conflicts:** The rising frequency of military coups, insurgencies, and political volatility, particularly in the **Sahel region** and parts of West Africa, creates a highly unpredictable environment that deters long-term Indian private sector investment.
 - **Structural Trade Bottlenecks and Non-Tariff Barriers:** Despite healthy trade volumes, optimal **Foreign Direct Investment (FDI)** is constrained by complex domestic regulatory landscapes across 54 different African nations, restrictive phytosanitary measures, and a persistent lack of direct aviation and maritime connectivity.
 - **Security of the Indian Diaspora:** Localized economic anxieties and high unemployment rates in certain African nations occasionally **trigger xenophobic violence or targeting of foreign nationals**.
 - Securing the 3 million-strong Indian diaspora requires delicate and persistent consular intervention.
 - **Constitutional Limitations on Paradiplomacy:** While state-led initiatives (like Telangana's outreach) are economically beneficial, foreign affairs strictly remain under the Union List (Entry 10, **7th Schedule**).
 - This structural reality can cause policy friction, requiring states to navigate complex central clearances before executing international MoUs.

What Measures can Strengthen India-Africa Relationship?

- **Institutionalizing Regular Summits:** The immediate reconvening of the IAFS-IV is critical. The summit must draft a post-pandemic, technology-first roadmap that is explicitly aligned with the **African Union's Agenda 2063**.
- **Formulating Sector-Specific Task Forces:** The immediate constitution of a Joint Working Group (JWG) on Critical Minerals is essential to secure uninterrupted, equitable supply lines required for India's domestic electric mobility and advanced semiconductor fabrication goals.
- **Streamlining Paradiplomatic Frameworks:** Expedite MEA guidelines to empower State Governments in their international commercial outreach, ensuring seamless execution of FDI attracted by proactive states.
- **Integrating Private Capital:** Indian diplomacy must actively incentivize MSMEs and conglomerates to transition from mere exporters to localized manufacturers within the AfCFTA framework, solidifying a **value-chain integrated economic model**.
- **Expanding Defense Capacity Building:** Beyond UN peacekeeping, India should escalate direct **defense cooperation, focusing on counter-terrorism training**, cybersecurity frameworks, and localized defense equipment manufacturing for African militaries.
- **Leveraging DPI as a Core Export:** Expanding the footprint of the **India Stack** to revolutionize African financial inclusion will inherently cement India's role as the primary technological enabler of the Global South, generating immense soft power and geopolitical goodwill.

Conclusion

Moving from shared history to shared prosperity, India-Africa ties are evolving from credit-led engagement to co-production, technology partnerships, and resilient supply chains. By deepening regional economic integration and securing strategic resources, the partnership is strengthening Global South cooperation and contributing to stability in an increasingly uncertain world.

Drishti Mains Question:

India's engagement with Africa is witnessing a shift from development assistance to strategic economic partnership. Examine.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the significance of the 2026 India-South Africa technology partnership upgrade?

It marks a shift from research-based cooperation to industrial co-production in emerging sectors such as AI, DPI, advanced manufacturing, genomics, hydrogen energy, and healthcare.

2. What is AfCFTA and why is it important for India?

AfCFTA is a USD 3.4 trillion integrated African market covering 1.4 billion people, offering India greater trade, investment, and manufacturing opportunities across the continent.

3 Why are critical minerals becoming central to India-Africa relations?

Africa's reserves of lithium, cobalt, and rare earth elements are crucial for India's EV ecosystem, semiconductor industry, and Green Hydrogen Mission.

4. How does India's engagement model in Africa differ from other major powers?

India emphasizes demand-driven development, capacity building, technology transfer, skill development, and transparent partnerships that respect African priorities.

5. What are the major challenges affecting India-Africa relations?

Implementation delays, China's growing influence, political instability, trade barriers, connectivity constraints, diaspora security concerns, and regulatory complexities continue to hinder deeper cooperation.

[Watch Video on YouTube:

▶ <https://www.youtube.com/embed/h-1YQTKEjS8>

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UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. In which one of the following groups are all the four countries members of G20? (2020)

- (a) Argentina, Mexico, South Africa and Turkey
- (b) Australia, Canada, Malaysia and New Zealand
- (c) Brazil, Iran, Saudi Arabia and Vietnam
- (d) Indonesia, Japan, Singapore and South Korea

Ans: (a)

Mains

Q. India-Africa digital partnership is achieving mutual respect, co-development and long-term institutional partnerships. Elaborate. (2025)

Q. 'The long-sustained image of India as a leader of the oppressed and marginalised nations has disappeared on account of its new found role in the emerging global order.' Elaborate. (2019)

US Proposes 12.5% Tariff on India Over Forced Labour Concerns



Source: TH

The **United States Trade Representative (USTR)** proposed an additional **12.5% tariff on imports from India** and 53 other economies. This action follows an investigation under **Section 301 of the US Trade Act of 1974**, citing the failure of these nations to effectively enforce regulations prohibiting the **import of goods produced using 'forced labour.'**

- **Section 301 of the US Trade Act of 1974:** Under this US investigates and imposes trade sanctions on foreign countries whose trade practices are deemed "**unjustifiable,**" "**unreasonable,**" or **discriminatory**, and which burden US commerce.
 - It allows the US President and the USTR to unilaterally impose tariffs or trade restrictions, often bypassing the **multilateral dispute settlement mechanism of the [World Trade Organization \(WTO\)](#)**.
- **India's Stance:** India stringently prohibits forced labour domestically under **[Article 23 of the Constitution \(Right against Exploitation\)](#)** and the **[Bonded Labour System \(Abolition\) Act, 1976](#)**.
 - India maintains that the allegations primarily **stem from global supply chain linkages rather than domestic practices**.
 - India has formally stated that it remains engaged with the US on this matter. The proposed tariffs are not yet final.
- **Reduced Export Competitiveness :** A 12.5% additional duty could make Indian exports more expensive in the US market, particularly affecting **labour-intensive sectors such as textiles, garments, carpets, leather products, and brassware**, as well as **automobiles, electronics, and engineering goods**, due to higher tariff burdens.
- **Supply Chain Disruptions:** Indian firms may need to reduce dependence on Chinese inputs to avoid tariffs, leading to higher sourcing and production costs in the short term.

Read more: [Navigating India-US Ties](#)